was the head of state from 2011 through to 2016. Shwe Mann and Khin Aung Myint, who served the transitional government in pivotal roles as speakers of the Union Assembly, also had backgrounds as top commanders in the military regime (Chit Win, this volume). Their civilian reincarnation was accompanied by important changes to the country's security agencies (see Selth 2014) and to the range of opportunities for popular participation in the political process (Lall and Hla Hla Win 2013). During this phase of democratic development, the Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP) dominated the legislature in Naypyitaw and also held large majorities in the fourteen states and regions. They learned to work with a range of ethnic and democratic political parties, and also with their uniformed military peers. Over time, the USDP became fractious, with dueling powerbrokers in the legislature and the executive vying for control. Among the democratic forces, Aung San Suu Kyi's National League for Democracy (NLD), which had boycotted the 2010 election, ended up winning seats at the 2012 by-election. With elected representatives serving in the country's legislatures, Myanmar's iconic opposition movement quietly went about the business of re-establishing a vibrant nationwide network of campaigners.

During these transitional years, progress towards economic, political and social reform was inconsistent. While the government confidently adjusted some critical policies and benefited from renewed foreign interest, those who had anticipated a more thorough transformation of society were immensely frustrated. For any progress, the Thein Sein government needed to coordinate with the armed forces, and with reluctant elements among the USDP (Maung Aung Myoe 2014). Thein Sein's civilianised administration did enough, however, to enjoy a partially rehabilitated international image (see Tin Maung Maung Than 2012, pp. 75–76). Welcoming the NLD into the formal political arrangement was crucial in this regard. In mid-2013 the World Economic Forum put on a grand investment summit, before Myanmar hosted the Southeast Asian Games (for details on the games see Creak 2014) and then, in 2014, the country chaired the Association of Southeast Asian Nations for the first time. The ASEAN and East Asia Summits held toward the end of 2014 were an opportunity to showcase the increasing vibrancy of Myanmar society. Attention then turned to preparations for the 2015 general election. While the floods of mid-2015 affected many people, the elections ended up running smoothly and were judged reasonably free and fair by independent observers. In the final tally, the NLD was triumphant, going on to hold over sixty per cent of seats in the Union Assembly (see Min Zin